

BEFORE

At the collapse of the Egyptian Old Kingdom << 56–57 centralized rule broke down and an unsettled time known as the First Intermediate Period (c. 2180–2040 BCE) began.

FIRST INTERMEDIATE PERIOD

Egypt saw **civil war**, **drought** and **famine**, and oppression by local **tyrants**. However, the greater powers of nonroyals at the end of the Old Kingdom ushered in some broader-minded thinking, including a **better justice** system for all.

HERAKLEOPOLIS VERSUS THEBES

One of the **competing factions** was a dynasty of kings based at Herakleopolis, central Egypt. They were bitter rivals of the **Theban kings** farther south.

REUNIFICATION

In the 11th Dynasty, Thebes sealed its rise to prominence when Theban king, **Nebhepetre Mentuhotep II** (c. 2060–2010 BCE; right), defeated his rivals from Herakleopolis. He **reunified Egypt** and so took it into the **Middle Kingdom** era.



NEBHEPETRE MENTUHOTEP II

Traditionally, ancient Egyptian history is seen as periods of order and prosperity separated by “intermediate” periods of chaos. Historians now think this is an overexaggerated contrast, but prosperous eras under strong centralized rule were certainly separated by times of division. Through all of this, however, ancient Egyptian culture and ways of life continued with surprising consistency for thousands of years—far longer than those of any other ancient civilization.

Middle Kingdom

Often said to last from Dynasty 11 to Dynasty 13, the Middle Kingdom (c. 2040–1730 BCE) saw Thebes becoming a major royal center, although the seat of government stayed near Memphis (see



Keeping order

Powerful figures called viziers, as depicted by this 12th-dynasty statue, headed the administration of the Middle Kingdom. In the New Kingdom, one took control in Lower Egypt and another in Upper Egypt.

also on irrigation systems (for example, at Fayum near Memphis) that benefited all. The country’s defenses were strengthened and new trade routes sprang up. Nubia, which came under Egyptian control, supplied not only gold and copper, but also the labor to mine these, as well as personnel for Egypt’s army.

Disorder and restoration

The Middle Kingdom’s stability dissolved when local governors pushed for more power. Civil war brought about another unsettled era—the Second Intermediate Period (c. 1730–1550 BCE; late Dynasty 13 to 17). During this time, a people called the Hyksos gained control and ruled Lower Egypt as pharaohs. Egyptian

dynasties continued to rule Upper Egypt from Thebes. Theban rulers triumphed when the Hyksos were finally expelled

and statues of Rameses II (c. 1279–1213 BCE; see pp.66–67) were erected. Southern Theban culture prevailed, with Thebes being rebuilt and great temples erected to the sun god, Amun-Ra. Royalty was now buried in elaborate underground tombs, centered on Thebes’ Valley of the Kings. Amenophis IV (1352–1336 BCE) took sun worship to extremes, bending his kingdom to the cult of Aten—worship of the sun’s disk alone—and renaming himself Akhenaten in honor of his beliefs (see pp.68–69).

379 The number of diplomatic letters in the archive of El-Amarna, Akhenaten’s capital, recording Egypt’s role as the world’s leading power.

Just as the Old and Middle Kingdoms had dissolved, so did the New Kingdom. It is unclear why outside threats (see AFTER) again became impossible to hold back. Rebellion and internal corruption may have played a part, but the truth remains a mystery.

Egypt in Order and Chaos

Over 100 years of uncertainty and lack of centralized control followed the collapse of Old Kingdom Egypt. However, order and glory were restored once again with the great Middle Kingdom and New Kingdom eras, which were themselves separated by another period of some disorder.

pp.56–57) at the new city of Itj-Towy. Middle Kingdom Egypt had a distinct character, but it was not as different from the Old Kingdom as once thought. In the 12th Dynasty, the royals regained a strong grip—perhaps as strong as in Old Kingdom times. The pharaoh took back some powers from nobles, but society did not return to a more feudal-type structure (in which powerless laborers worked for the pharaoh)—society was more democratic.

Rise of the bureaucrat

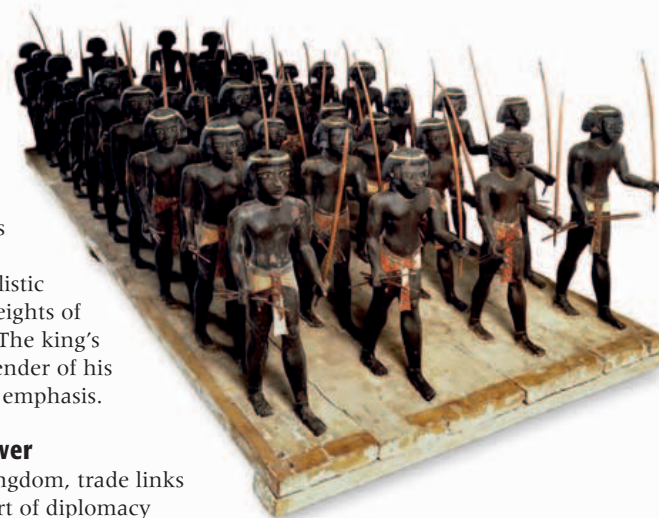
One of society’s democratic features was that posts formerly held by royals passed to high-ranking “civil servants.” Egypt was now run more like a corporation than an extension of the royal family. Greater rights for ordinary people included access to mummification (see pp.68–69), and more interest was taken in the poor and needy. Money was spent not only on royal tombs but

under pharaoh Amose I, and the New Kingdom (c. 1550–1069 BCE; Dynasties 18 to 20) began. This era is often seen as a time of glorious “empire,” with a militaristic, nationalistic outlook and new heights of wealth and power. The king’s role as warrior-defender of his lands gained a new emphasis.

New kingdom power

During the New Kingdom, trade links extended and the art of diplomacy intensified, as seen in the famous Amarna letters and the treaty of Kadesh (see pp.66–67, 78–79). Egypt quashed threats to the throne, thanks greatly to warfare techniques borrowed from the Hyksos—especially the use of two-wheeled, horse-drawn chariots that were fast and lightweight.

The New Kingdom was an age of spectacular architecture and art. The lavish tomb contents of the pharaoh Tutankhamun (c. 1336–1327 BCE) were interred and the monumental buildings



In-fighting

Private armies abounded during the Intermediate Periods, gathered by the leaders of regional factions fighting endlessly for control. This model army of Nubian archers is from the tomb of a governor of Asyut.

New Kingdom opulence

Queen Ankhesenamen anoints her young king, Tutankhamun, in a scene taken from a gold-inlaid throne entombed with the pharaoh in the Valley of the Kings. Tutankhamun’s short reign continued the New Kingdom’s grandeur and returned Egypt to its traditional religious practices after the Aten-cult worship of his predecessor, Akhenaten.



Height of Egyptian control

Egypt’s lands reached their height under New Kingdom pharaoh Thutmose III (c. 1479–1425 BCE). Marked here are major centers of royal, religious, and administrative control during the Old, Middle, and New Kingdoms.